

PURR-FECT
An African cheetah at the Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh

This first-of-its-kind experiment will be put to the test once the cheetahs are released into the wild

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2022 saw the fastest land animal making a return to India 70 years after it was hunted to extinction

By Rahul Noronha

Seven decades after they were hunted to extinction in India, cheetahs made a comeback with much fanfare, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi released eight big cats translocated from Namibia at the Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh on September 17, which was also his birthday. The ambitious plan finally saw the light of day 50 years after being first conceived. Initially, it involved getting Asiatic cheetahs from Iran, which failed to materialise. Revived in 2009, the plan suffered another setback in 2012, after the Supreme Court stayed this first-of-its-kind intercontinental carnivore translocation. The final nod came in 2020.

After being flown to India, the cheetahs—three males (Elton, Freddy and Obaan) and five females (Aasha, Sasha, Tbilisi, Siyaya and Savannah)—were first kept in a quarantine facility. They have since been moved to a bigger enclosure and have acclimatised well to their new home, corroborated by the successful kills of spotted deer and blue bull. With the introduction of cheetahs moving as per the plan so far, doubts surrounding the project—which for long faced fierce opposition from the conservation fraternity—are beginning to dispel. Meanwhile, the MP government has made big plans to develop the area as a tourist hub, with tigers being reintroduced at the Madhav National Park in the neighbouring Shivpuri district.

The next key, and the most awaited, move is the release of these cheetahs into the wild, which is expected within a couple of months. It will put this unprecedented experiment to the real test, allowing these fastest land animals to finally venture towards the park's periphery, where they risk coming in contact with humans. The next lot of 12 cheetahs—this time from South Africa—is also expected to arrive at Kuno by January-end. ■